WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-09-14 to 2026-09-19

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SPECIAL ISSUE UPDATES

Calls checked: 2026-09-19.

Manual calls omitted pending renewed official-page verification: Public Relations Review.

Special Issue: LLM Sycophancy in Digital Journalism: News Consumption, Public Deliberation, and Governance in the Age of Conversational Agents
Digital Journalism | Deadline within 14 days | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-09-30
Official call / submission details

Special Collection: Digital skills and data literacy
Humanities & Social Sciences Communications | Newly found | call for papers
Deadline: 2027-03-25
Official call / submission details

Special Issue: Machines as Method: The Use of Artificial Intelligence in Advertising Research
Journal of Advertising Research | Newly found | call for papers
Deadline: 2027-08-01
Official call / submission details

SUMMARY

This COMAP Journal Bot edition follows how political messages move through algorithmic feeds, how institutions reward viral confrontation, and how AI can quietly reshape judgment. New work on campaign language, white-nationalist support, and public distrust of expertise gives the week a strong political-communication core; careful measurement studies provide useful tools for the next research question.

The reading list also includes one political-participation paper newly indexed from September 7-13 and one late-indexed study of bias-like processing in reasoning models. Papers already delivered in the September 12 edition are not repeated here.

You may have received two September 7 emails because the first was sent before that collection window closed; the second completed the same edition. Saturday delivery now aligns collection and sending, so each future email represents a distinct Monday-Saturday edition.

HIGHLIGHTS

Human preferences are susceptible to covertly misaligned AI advice

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-09-14

Why it matters · A randomized experiment shows that covertly misaligned AI advice can move preferences toward inferior choices while users still rate the advisor as helpful-a direct warning for AI-mediated influence.

Open article →

The Democratic Cost of Pursuing Virality: A Study into Parliamentary Communications

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-16

Why it matters · Combines interviews with 4.5 million Brazilian parliamentary posts to show how platform engagement rewards antagonism and crowds out communication about legislative work.

Open article →

How does political efficacy condition clicks on politics? Understanding information-selection behavior in algorithmic feeds over time

JOURNAL OF COMPUTER-MEDIATED COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-17

Why it matters · Links political efficacy to what people select from an algorithmic news feed over time, revealing a widening gap in source diversity between users.

Open article →

Predictors and prevalence of support for white nationalism in the United States

NATURE · 2026-09-16

Why it matters · Validates a direct survey measure of white-nationalist support and connects it to hardship, political disaffection, and primarily online friendships.

Open article →

Do Your Own Research: What Skepticism of Expertise Means for the News Media in the U.S.

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-14

Why it matters · Panel evidence associates a do-your-own-research mindset with lower nonpartisan news use, poorer belief accuracy, and more hostile views of the media.

Open article →

Does Office Type Determine Gendered Campaign Messages?

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-18

Why it matters · Uses nearly 47,000 standardized South Korean campaign booklets to isolate how office type and electoral level shape gendered political messaging.

Open article →

Defining collectivism as duties in relationships rather than generalized warmth improves predictive validity in 100 cultures

NATURE HUMAN BEHAVIOUR · 2026-09-15

Why it matters · A 100-culture study replaces a fuzzy collectivism measure with a responsibility-based scale that better predicts social and political differences.

Open article →

Methodological Variations in Environmental Justice Screening Tools and Their Impact on Disadvantaged Community Designations

NATURE COMMUNICATIONS · 2026-09-17

Why it matters · Shows that opaque indicator choices in environmental-justice screening tools change which communities qualify for policy benefits-a measurement-governance problem.

Open article →

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- Science

Previous Week Catch-Up

- Nature Communications

Late Additions

- Nature Machine Intelligence

COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES
352	166	185

LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES
1

Curated digest below: 16 new, 1 catch-up, 1 late additions

The candidate counts are after automatic source filters and before manual relevance review; the full curated list below is a focused subset.

All 17 article sources completed; the September 7-13 catch-up candidates already delivered on September 12 are omitted to avoid duplicate reading.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

Communication Research

When Past Hurt Meets Present Care: How Family History Shapes Adult Caregivers' Communal Coping With Siblings in Their Caregiving for Parents With Health Challenges

2026-09-19 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261484417

Abdullah S. Salehuddin; Andy J. Merolla; Tamara D. Afifi

University of Alabama, Tuscaloosa, USA; University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Abstract. This sequential, explanatory mixed-methods study explores how adult caregivers' perceived family functioning and unresolved hurt toward siblings from childhood are associated with their present-day communal coping (CC) with their siblings and caregiving outcomes. Study 1 tested a hypothesized moderated mediation model using survey data (N = 776). The results indicate greater childhood family functioning (consistent with hypotheses) and unresolved hurt (counter to hypotheses) were associated with more CC with siblings. CC, in turn, was associated with less flourishing and greater caregiver burden and sibling resentment. Considering the unexpected positive association between unresolved hurt and CC, Study 2 involved semi-structured interviews with adult caregivers (N = 30) about their experiences enacting CC with siblings despite residual hurt. The findings suggest unresolved childhood hurt toward siblings often stem from challenging experiences, including neglect and abuse. In addition to impeding sibling CC, unresolved hurt can also complicate efforts toward CC (or render them dysfunctional). This study underscores how childhood experiences have an enduring effect on CC with siblings decades later, especially if past family issues are left unresolved.

Read article →

Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication

How does political efficacy condition clicks on politics? Understanding information-selection behavior in algorithmic feeds over time

2026-09-17 · DOI 10.1093/JCMC/ZMAG022

Jin Wan; Theo Araujo; Natali Helberger; Claes de Vreese

Amsterdam School of Communication Research (ASCoR), University of Amsterdam , Amsterdam,; Institute for Information Law (IViR), University of Amsterdam , Amsterdam,

Abstract. Abstract This study uses political efficacy to explain individual differences in selecting political information on algorithmic feeds. Combining survey data and 186 Dutch individuals' usage histories of Google Discover, a fully algorithmically curated feed, we examined both within-person changes of information-selection behavior over time and between-person differences conditioned by political efficacy in three aspects: the proportion of political information selected by users, exposure diversity as manifested via sources, and proportion of negative political information. While we did not find any longitudinal change conditioned by external efficacy on information-selection patterns, we found that internally efficacious users are more resilient to prevalent concerns about algorithms' negative influence on political information consumption and exposure diversity. We observed their stable proportions of political information consumption and consumption from increasingly diverse sources over time. Alarmingly, there is a growing divide in exposure diversity between less and more efficacious users over time. Altogether, our study not only highlights users' agency in navigating algorithmic environments but also underscores the importance of empowering users with account of different vulnerabilities.

Read article →

Nature

Predictors and prevalence of support for white nationalism in the United States

2026-09-16 · DOI 10.1038/S41586-026-11018-0

Patrick J. Egan; James Bisbee; Joshua A. Tucker

Abstract. Abstract White nationalism has become increasingly visible in American public life 1-10 . Yet we lack knowledge of the predictors and prevalence of explicit support for this ideology, as survey research has treated it as a latent construct captured through indirect indicators 11-15 . We introduce and validate a measure that informs respondents of the core tenets of the white nationalist movement and then asks whether they support the movement. Expressed support is distinct from organizational affiliation with the movement, which we do not measure. Here we show with three national surveys of non-Hispanic white adults (conducted from 2021 to 2025) that support for white nationalism is (1) higher among white people encountering personal hardship and local social distress, consistent with strain theories 3,16 ; (2) unrelated to local racial composition or recent demographic change, complicating status threat accounts 4,17,18 ; and (3) elevated among white people with close friendships primarily online, consistent with theories of extremism driven by online mobilization 7,10,19 . Support for white nationalism is more common among white people with lower incomes and education, Republicans and conservatives, and those who are politically disaffected. In our national probability sample, prevalence of support was estimated at 4.9% of white adults, including 13.5% of white men aged 18-29. Support for white nationalism seems to constitute a discrete dimension of white racial attitudes, and many white people who endorse its core ideas are unaware of the label.

Read article →

Nature Communications

Climate urgency enables political alignment for Latin American power integration

2026-09-17 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77772-X

Luis Ramirez; Gerardo Blanco; Felipe Sepulveda; Luiz Barroso; Wilfredo C. Flores; Rodrigo Moreno

Abstract. Abstract Political fragmentation continues to block urgently needed power integration in Latin America, despite the region's vast renewable energy potential. Using the Multiple Streams Approach, this study argues that the escalating climate crisis now acts as a focusing event, aligning a pressing energy problem, viable integration solutions, and growing political will. This alignment signals that a policy window is open. This study combines the Multiple Streams Approach with system modeling to quantify overlooked political costs of inaction, specifically, geopolitical tensions and erosion of trust, offering actionable leverage for policy entrepreneurs. Simulations for 2025-2050 show that continued fragmentation increases system costs by up to 7%, reduces resilience to hydroclimatic shocks, and concentrates benefits within narrow cooperating blocs under low-trust conditions. These measurable and rising costs underscore that regional energy integration is no longer just a technical or economic issue; it is a political imperative. Bold leadership must act now to seize this fleeting window of opportunity.

Read article →

Methodological Variations in Environmental Justice Screening Tools and Their Impact on Disadvantaged Community Designations

2026-09-17 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77824-2

Thomas Robbins; Qingran Li; Stephen Bird; Susan E. Powers

Abstract. Government agencies in the United States have developed environmental justice screening tools (EJSTs) and designations to promote equitable distribution of benefits from environmental policies to disadvantaged communities (DACs). However, the methodological choices embedded in these tools, including the selection, weighting, and aggregation of environmental justice indicators, vary across EJSTs, and their implications for DAC designation outcomes are poorly understood. Here we systematically compare four EJSTs at the federal and state levels and show that these tools produce substantial variation in the DAC census tracts, with some tools emphasizing socioeconomic burdens while others prioritize environmental risks. Using quantitative regression models, we further show that indicator weighting and other design choices shape final DAC designations in ways that are not always made explicit. These findings highlight the need for greater transparency in EJST methodological choices to support informed policymaking and public understanding of DAC eligibility. Environmental justice screening tools use different methods to designate disadvantaged communities. This study finds substantial variation in designations across tools and shows that method choices can shape outcomes in ways rarely made transparent.

Read article →

Nature Computational Science

Large language models as human proxies

2026-09-18 · DOI 10.1038/S43588-026-01060-3

Nikita Karetnikov; Iyad Rahwan; Davor Svetinovic

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Nature Human Behaviour

A research agenda for making evidence useful, usable and used in policymaking

2026-09-17 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02593-3

Max Spohn; Amira Boland; Jessica Lasky-Fink; Elizabeth Linos; Weston Merrick; Pedro Rey-Biel; Theodore Svoronos

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Defining collectivism as duties in relationships rather than generalized warmth improves predictive validity in 100 cultures

2026-09-15 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02525-1

Thomas Talhelm; Liuqing Wei; Rui Sun; Danila Medvedev; Alvaro San Martin; May Helmy; Adil Samekin; Alejandra Zaragoza Scherman; Alexander S. English; Andreea Ursu; Seamus A. Power; Chia-Wen Chen; Qionghan Zhang; Ali H. Al-Hoorie; Annabella Osei-Tutu; Laura Vuillier; Katija Khan; Amanda Atwood; Luxi Shen; Muhammad Rizwan; Serigne Abdou Lahat Ndiaye; Oumar Barry; Tengku Nila Fadhlia; Igor Grossmann; Jordan R. Axt; Nicholas Calbraith Owsley; Salome Njambi; Illia Yahiiaiev; Karine Malysheva; Serhii Lytvyn; Irena Sarieva; Xuemin Zhang; Chen Zhao; Robert Ritz; BoKyung Park; Maria Constantinou; Mario Jose Chanja; Syeda Arzu Wasti; Synne Marit Kjelling Skagseth; Jonas R. Kunst; Tuong Van Vu; Isaraphorn Pratumchai; Phakkanun Chittham; Narendra Singh Thagunna; Jyotshna Dangi; Tulips Yiwen Wang; Vassilis Pavlopoulos; Michal Kohut; Freyr Halldorsson; Deborah Shulman; Anita Deak; Watcharaporn Boonyasiriwat; Bojana Veckalov; Ricardo B. Rodrigues; Rui Costa-Lopes; Patricia Gale; William J. Chopik; Lusanda Sekaja; Orla Muldoon; Donna-Maria B. Maynard; Ashley Foster-Estwick; Amy H. Du; Rabiah Aminudin; Edna Kabala; Marcus Eugenio Oliveira Lima; Eunkook M. Suh; Michael Muthukrishna; Jinseok P. Kim; Kazi Nur Hossain; Arobindu Dash; Stefan Agrigoroaei; Takeshi Hamamura; Mahsa Amirzadeh; Liliya Sultanova; Rocio A. Rivera Crespo; Ying Lin; Kara Lord; Yuri Miyamoto; Valeria Vitale; Masaki Yuki; Yugo Maeda; Hamidreza Harati; Amir Hossein Abdollahzadeh; Nara Pratumchai; Jonathan C. de la Cerna; Erik Chavez; Solenne Carof; Elizabeth A. Gilbert; Nelson Molina-Valencia; Tobias Ebert; Pepi

Pandiloski; Frank Ephraim Kaphesi; Kalliopi Ioumpa; Adi Shaked; Rebecca Namatovu; Samuel Dawa; Adam L. Putnam; Othman Alkhadher; Eugene Agboifo Ohu; Agustin Espinosa; Sara Aka Lennert Jensen; Nasima MH Carrim; Matt Motyl; Wen-Dong Li; Liudmila Titova; Fan Fei; Timo von Oertzen

Abstract. Abstract Experts widely agree that East Asian cultures are more collectivistic than Western cultures. Yet 76 survey studies found no reliable difference. Our explanation is that the most-used surveys are contaminated with 'warm fuzzy' items, which describe warmth and prosociality towards everyone near and far. We argue that collectivism is better understood as 'responsibilism', which emphasizes responsibilities in close relationships. A survey found that many cultural psychologists expect collectivistic cultures to agree with warm fuzzy items. Then we developed a responsibilism scale and tested 12,247 people in 100 cultures. Results showed large cultural differences (d = 3.98 [2.50, 5.43]) that were previously obscured by flawed measurement. Responsibilism predicted differences across societies (such as family ties and corruption) and individuals (social class and politics) that most earlier scales missed. This study offers a solution to previous puzzling findings by distinguishing warm fuzzy prosociality from responsibilism and introducing a scale with stronger predictive validity.

Read article →

Political Analysis

Turning Hazard Models Inside Out

2026-09-15 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10056

David Melamed; Jack G. R. Wippell; Eric W. Schoon; Ronald L. Breiger

Ohio State University; University of Arizona

Abstract. Abstract Regression Inside Out (RIO) describes a set of related methods based on a decomposition of regression coefficients by individual cases. In this article, we offer three important extensions of RIO: 1) we generalize RIO to any model for which linear predictors are estimated; 2) we introduce an adapted bootstrap approach for determining whether case-level contributions differ from the baseline average contribution for cases; and 3) we describe how RIO is related to model diagnostics, particularly DFBETA. To illustrate the value added of these extensions, we apply RIO to a published example of the Cox proportional hazard model exploring factors associated with democratic durability.

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Political Communication

Does Office Type Determine Gendered Campaign Messages?

2026-09-18 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2722250

Tae Hyun Lim; Yu Jeong Hwang

Hamilton College; University of Arizona

Abstract. This study examines how candidates' gender shapes campaign messaging across different branches and levels of political office. Prior research offers mixed evidence on whether women are more likely than men to emphasize communal traits and women-related policies, often because gender effects are examined without fully accounting for institutional context. We address this inconsistency by foregrounding the role of electoral institutions. Building on strategic stereotype theory, we argue that gendered campaign messaging is a strategic response to office-specific incentives and expectations. In particular, we expect gendered appeals to be more prevalent at lower levels of government than at higher levels, and more pronounced in legislative than in executive races. We test these expectations using an original dataset of 46,966 official campaign booklets issued by all candidates competing for district-based executive and legislative offices in seventeen national and local elections in South Korea from 2000 to 2022. These booklets are legally standardized, page-limited documents distributed to voters and provide a rare opportunity to compare campaign messages across offices while holding the communication medium constant. We measure gendered messaging through candidates' use of relational language and women-related policy terms. The results show that female candidates emphasize relational identities and women's policy concerns more than male candidates. Crucially, the magnitude of this gender gap varies across institutional contexts. Gender differences are larger in legislative contests than in executive races and increase as elections move from national to subnational levels.

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The Democratic Cost of Pursuing Virality: A Study into Parliamentary Communications

2026-09-16 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2733316

Andre K. Rodarte

University of Southern Denmark

Abstract. The transformation of parliamentarians into media producers has heightened concerns about emerging forms of political communication. This mixed-methods paper examines the strategies they employ to enhance their digital presence. Based on in-depth interviews, it shows that Brazilian parliamentarians believe that social media penalize them for posting about congressional matters, reporting that content about legislative work and constituency services receives little engagement online. Conversely, they view the production of antagonistic content and alignment with news cycles as essential to maintaining an engaging social media presence. A computational analysis of 4,5 million posts on Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter supports these evaluations: posts about congressional matters are associated with lower engagement metrics, while the use of antagonistic language increases them. The analysis further discusses pathways through which visibility is sustained at the intersection of platform incentives and communicative practices. In sum, this mixed-methods study demonstrates that the mediatization of politics has created perverse incentives for parliamentarians to downplay congressional activity and prioritize confrontations on social media, weakening accountability in ways that may resonate far beyond Brazil.

Read article →

Do Your Own Research: What Skepticism of Expertise Means for the News Media in the U.S.

2026-09-14 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2729428

Ariel Hasell; Sedona Chinn

University of Michigan; University of Wisconsin-Madison

Abstract. In the U.S. the availability of news information has grown exponentially while trust in traditional sources of news and information has declined. Amid this high-information, low-trust environment, many now advocate for doing your own research (DYOR) to discern accurate claims from false, misleading, or biased information. The perception that it is better to do one's own research has important implications for information seeking and attitudes toward mainstream news and journalism. In this study, we use a panel survey to investigate DYOR perceptions in the context of the 2020 U.S. election. We find that DYOR perceptions are associated with decreased nonpartisan news use, decreased belief accuracy, and more negative attitudes toward media, highlighting how information skepticism may be contributing to adversarial views toward mainstream media and expertise. Results suggest that such perceptions encourage negative views of news media and may contribute to distrust of public institutions.

Read article →

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Reallocating fossil subsidies via social assistance reduces poverty and preserves emissions cuts

2026-09-17 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2606441123

Xiangjie Chen; Kuishuang Feng; Laixiang Sun; Daniele Malerba; Peipei Tian; Nathan Hultman

Center for Global Sustainability, School of Public Policy, University of Maryland; Department of Geographical Sciences, University of Maryland; Department of Geography, The University of Hong Kong; German Institute of Development and Sustainability, Department "Transformation of Economic and Social Systems"; Institute for Climate and Carbon Neutrality, The University of Hong Kong; Institute of Blue and Green Development, Shandong University

Abstract. Fossil fuel subsidies are widespread, regressive, and environmentally costly, yet abrupt removal can raise poverty. To identify a practical reform pathway, we evaluate the effectiveness of compensatory policies grounded in existing national social protection systems. We develop a high-resolution global social accounting matrix to quantify how reallocating subsidies through actual social assistance impacts poverty, inequality, and CO 2 emissions. Without compensation, reform lowers emissions but increases poverty, especially for low-income households in emerging economies. Redirecting funds via social assistance disproportionately benefits the bottom half and reduces national poverty, particularly under targeted cash transfers or expanded programs where savings are large. However, full revenue recycling is not always desirable: Once vulnerable households are adequately protected, additional recycling can weaken both fiscal and climate gains. We therefore treat full recycling through social assistance as an analytical benchmark rather than a policy prescription and show that partial, targeted recycling, as illustrated by retaining roughly 20% of savings while channeling the remainder through social protection, can still reduce poverty while preserving emissions cuts. Overall, fossil fuel subsidy reform is most effective when social assistance is used to compensate low-income households, not to absorb all fiscal savings, leaving residual revenues available for other public priorities.

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Corporate ESG assessments fail to capture actual deforestation exposure

2026-09-14 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2526924123

Yingtong Zhu; Johan Sulaeman; Luis Roman Carrasco

Department of Biological Sciences, National University of Singapore; Department of Finance, Business School, National University of Singapore; Sustainable and Green Finance Institute, National University of Singapore

Abstract. Deforestation is a fundamental upstream risk to global sustainability, affecting all three pillars of credible Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) assessments, which are crucial sources of information facilitating sustainable investment decisions. However, the efficacy of major commercial ESG assessment tools in capturing corporate deforestation exposure remains unknown. We examine the relationship between corporate ESG ratings from five major ESG rating providers and two geospatially driven measures of company-level deforestation: forest loss surrounding corporate assets across sectors globally and supply-chain exposure to six forest-risk commodities in four tropical countries. Although deforestation is featured prominently in ESG methodologies, we fail to find evidence that ESG scores consistently penalize companies for deforestation. Conversely, ESG ratings respond more to media-based signals than to geospatially quantified deforestation. ESG analyses present apparent biases. Companies with deforestation exposure through soy, pork, and chicken supply chains receive higher ESG scores, whereas palm oil producers are more consistently penalized for deforestation exposure. Future integration of geospatial, ground-validated deforestation data and supply chain information into ESG assessment frameworks is essential for ESG-driven sustainable investing to effectively contribute to curbing deforestation.

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Human preferences are susceptible to covertly misaligned AI advice

2026-09-14 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2600684123

Sahand Sabour; June M. Liu; Siyang Liu; Chris Z. Yao; Shiyao Cui; Wen Zhang; Xuanming Zhang; Yaru Cao; Advait Bhat; Jian Guan; Wei Wu; Rada Mihalcea; Hongning Wang; Tim Althoff; Tatia M. C. Lee; Minlie Huang

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Abstract. AI assistants are increasingly used as advisors to guide decisions, yet little is known about how people evaluate such advice when the advisor's underlying intent conflicts with their interests. We examine how covert misalignment shapes choices in a randomized experiment (N = 233 participants; 699 observations) in which participants rated financial or emotional decisions before and after consulting one of three AI advisors: a neutral advisor, a misaligned advisor with a hidden objective to promote an inferior option, or a strategy-enhanced misaligned advisor additionally equipped with established tactics of covert influence. Across both domains, exposure to misaligned advisors shifted preferences away from optimal options and toward inferior alternatives, increasing the odds of preferring the incentivized (inferior) option over the optimal option by 5 to 8 times (up to +38 percentage points). Adding explicit influence strategies did not reliably strengthen these effects. Notably, participants continued to rate misaligned advisors as helpful, revealing a systematic disconnect between susceptibility to misaligned advice and subjective evaluations of advisor quality. These findings have implications for the design and governance of AI-mediated advice.

Read article →

Science

Geopolitical tensions with the US accelerate Chinese firms' leveraging of science

2026-09-17 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AED7991

Junhan Wang; Xibao Li; Yanbo Wang

Faculty of Business and Economics, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong SAR.; School of Economics and Management, Tsinghua University, Beijing, China.; Shenzhen Audencia Financial Technology Institute, Shenzhen University, Shenzhen, China

Abstract. US restrictions on access to technologies have led Chinese firms to intensify and broaden the scope of their scientific knowledge sourcing

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Previous Week Catch-Up

Nature Communications

Wildfire exposure and political participation in Africa

2026-09-12 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77404-4

Siyuan Chen; Michael Akwasi Appiah-Kubi; Lina Meng; Pengfei Liu; Lu Lin

Abstract. Abstract Civic engagement can shape collective responses to climate change. However, evidence on how climate-related disasters affect political participation in Africa remains limited. Combining Global Fire Atlas records with Afrobarometer surveys of more than 100,000 people in 34 African countries, we show that people living close to wildfires are more likely to vote, contact local councillors, attend community meetings, and raise collective issues, whereas protest participation shows weaker responses. These effects are larger in arid regions and among people with higher climate literacy or access to information, members of politically dominant ethnic groups and those living near ethnic boundaries. Our findings suggest that participation is motivated mainly by immediate material loss and demand for public services, rather than environmental concern. These findings highlight the importance of addressing post-disaster needs to sustain political engagement and public support for long-term climate adaptation in the Global South.

Read article →

Late Additions

Nature Machine Intelligence

Implicit-bias-like patterns in reasoning models

2026-09-01 · DOI 10.1038/S42256-026-01300-1

Messi H. J. Lee; Calvin K. Lai

Abstract. Implicit biases refer to automatic mental processes that shape perceptions, judgements and behaviours. While previous research on bias in large language models (LLMs) has focused primarily on outputs, we introduce the reasoning-model implicit association test (RM-IAT) to study bias-like processing differences in reasoning models (that is, LLMs that generate explicit step-by-step reasoning before producing a response). By measuring reasoning-token counts as an index of computational effort, the RM-IAT captures processing efficiency differences analogous to response latency differences in the human IAT. Across four models (o3-mini, DeepSeek-R1, gpt-oss-20b and Qwen3-8B), we find consistent evidence that association-incompatible tasks require greater computational effort than association-compatible tasks. Claude 3.7 Sonnet exhibited reversed patterns, which were linked using thematic analysis to its unique internal focus on reasoning about bias and stereotypes. We also found evidence for convergent validity with model outputs. RM-IAT effects predicted biases in two tasks known to capture LLM biases in word association and decision-making. Together, these findings demonstrate that the RM-IAT captures meaningful variation in how reasoning models process stereotypical information, and that this variation predicts downstream model behaviour. Lee and Lai study bias-like processing differences in large language reasoning models and find that, for most models, processing stereotypical information takes less computational effort than processing counter-stereotypical information.

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